

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Book Intros)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Zechariah

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The people of God who had returned to Judea from exile were being oppressed by neighboring nations. As a result, they were discouraged, and they left their temple in ruins. The prophet Zechariah gave them hope with a vision of the future. God continued to love Jerusalem and the land of Judah. God's plan had not changed. God was going to live there again with his people and rule over all the earth.

Zechariah warned Israel not to repeat the sins that had led to their exile. He urged those who were unsure whether to follow God's truth or human wisdom to return to God. Zechariah told them to obey the commands of God's covenant (binding agreement), and practice justice throughout the land.

Setting

Cyrus, king of Persia, issued a decree in 538 BC that allowed people who had been taken from their lands by the Babylonians to return home (see Ezra 1:1-11). Sheshbazzar became the first governor of the restored community. He led the first Jewish group back to Jerusalem (Ezra 1:5-11).

During his time as governor, the returning Jews laid the foundation of a new temple (538-536 BC; see Ezra 5:16). However, they soon stopped the work. The temple site remained unfinished for almost 20 years while the people faced economic difficulties, political pressure and opposition, and spiritual decline (see Haggai 1-2).

In response to their troubles, God sent two prophets to lead the rebuilding of Jerusalem and to help his people return to him. The prophet Haggai preached for only four months in late 520 BC. He challenged the Jewish community to rebuild the temple in Jerusalem. The people responded positively to Haggai's message and began rebuilding the temple of the Lord that same year (Haggai 1:12-15).

The prophet Zechariah supported Haggai's message by calling for God's people to return to God and renew their commitment to him (Zechariah 1:3-6; 7:8-14). Zechariah's ministry in Jerusalem lasted for at least two years. The temple building project was completed in March 515 BC during the reign of Darius I, king of Persia (Ezra 5:2; 6:13-18).

Summary

Zechariah's task was to prepare the people to worship God properly in the temple after it was completed. He did this by correcting them, urging them to obey God, and encouraging them.

The people of Judah were committing obvious social and moral sins. They were resisting God and had become spiritually indifferent. Zechariah called them to return to God through true repentance (turning away from sin and back to God; Zechariah 1:3-5).

Only a renewed relationship with God could lead to true worship and faithful service in the temple that was being built. Only obedience to the Lord would bring the long-awaited blessings, prosperity, and righteousness of the messianic age (the time when God's anointed king would rule; 6:9-15; 8:13).

God's plan to bless Jerusalem depended on whether the people obeyed his laws, especially the laws about how they treated one another (7:8-12; 8:14-17). Before people from other nations would come to Jerusalem to seek the Lord, the people of Israel had to seek God, act justly, and show kindness and mercy to widows, orphans, and foreigners (7:9-10; 14:16-21).

Author

The book of Zechariah does not say who wrote it, but Zechariah likely wrote down his own messages. The opening verse (1:1) identifies him as the son of Berechiah and the grandson of Iddo. The book of Ezra confirms this (Ezra 5:1; 6:14).

Nehemiah tells us that Iddo returned to Jerusalem from exile in Babylon with Zerubbabel and Jeshua (Nehemiah 12:4). Nehemiah also lists Zechariah as the leader of the priestly family descended from Iddo (Neh 12:1, 16). This suggests that Zechariah was both a priest and a prophet in Jerusalem.

Date

Zechariah began his ministry just two months after Haggai's, in 520 BC. Zechariah delivered his last dated message in 518 BC. The first part of the book was probably written between 520 and 515 BC (chapters 1-8). Zechariah does not mention the completion and dedication of the temple in 515 BC (see Ezra 6:13-22).

Zechariah's undated messages (chapters 9-14) might indicate that his ministry continued well beyond the completion of the temple. He might have written these chapters later in life, possibly between 500 and 470 BC.

Some biblical scholars assign chapters 9–11 to a “Second Zechariah” and chapters 12–14 to a “Third Zechariah.” However, the language and writing style are very consistent throughout the book. In addition, archaeological evidence (information discovered from ancient sites and objects) and evidence from the historical and social setting support the view that the entire book was written as one work.

Recipients

Zechariah’s messages were for the people living in and around Jerusalem after their return from exile (1:3). Within Zechariah’s sermons and visions are words specifically addressed to the governor Zerubbabel, the high priest Jeshua, and the rest of the priests (see 3:8–9; 4:6–7; 7:4–7).

Literary Genre

Zechariah is prophetic literature containing messages that call God’s people to repentance, to renewed corporate worship, and to the practice of social justice.

In addition, Zechariah contains elements of apocalyptic literature (a type of writing that uses visions and symbols to reveal God’s plans). This kind of writing explains present events and speaks about future events through symbols and hidden meanings. It often presents visions that are explained by an angel (see 1:9).

The settings, characters, and events in apocalyptic literature often go beyond ordinary human experience. This type of writing announces that the present order will come to an end and points to a different future that God will bring about through his action in human history.

Later Jewish apocalyptic writings often focused on Israel’s future restoration in the day of the Lord (the time when God acts in a special way to judge evil and save his people). Zechariah’s prophecy focused more on justice in the people’s daily lives.

Three types of messages are often found in apocalyptic literature in the Bible:

1. encouragement for people who are suffering,
2. warnings to those who oppress others, and
3. calls to trust God for those who are unsure whether to follow God’s truth or human wisdom.

Meaning and Message

The book of Zechariah calls for repentance, spiritual renewal, and a return to right relationship with God (1:1–6). Zechariah’s role was to comfort and strengthen a small group (remnant) of God’s people who were

discouraged (1:13; 8:6–15). Zechariah also supported Haggai’s call to rebuild the temple in Jerusalem (8:9, 13).

Zechariah received messages as visions of the future. These visions promised:

- peace for Israel,
- judgment of the nations,
- the restoration of Jerusalem,
- responsible government by God’s appointed leadership, and
- right living among God’s people (1:7–6:15).

Zechariah stressed that social justice was the right way for Israel to respond to God (7:8–12; 8:14–17).

Zechariah’s last two messages provide hope by focusing on Israel’s future restoration (chapters 9–14). The prophet predicts:

- the Lord’s return to the temple (9:8–10),
- Israel’s rescue from enemies (12:1–14), and
- the establishment of God’s kingdom in Jerusalem (14:9–11).

Zechariah also speaks about the coming Messiah, who would be a suffering shepherd (13:7) and a righteous king (9:9). He would bring salvation to Israel and peace to the nations (9:10, 16).